

Affixal verbs in Chukchi and Even: different origins affect morphosyntax

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Our study deals with syntax and semantics of bound denominal verbalizers (see Gerdts & Marlett 2008) in Chukchi (< Chukotko-Kamchatkan, 17 affixes) and Even (< Tungusic, 18 affixes). Semantically, these verbalizers form a continuum from abstract ones to those expressing events commonly encoded by verbal roots (like ‘hunt’, ‘smell’ inter alia). To differentiate the latter from other types of lexical affixes (e.g. describing objects, see Mithun 1997; Matissen 2017) we label them as *affixal verbs* (AV further). In this paper we analyze AV semantics and syntax refining previous descriptions (e.g. Kurebito 2001 for Chukchi). The data was gathered during our fieldwork on Chukchi (Amguema variety, Amguema village, 2016-2023) and Even (Bystraja dialect, Esso and Anavgaj villages, 2021-2023). We used both elicitation data and text analysis (written and oral).

Semantically, there are similarities (AV for hunting, gathering and eating) as well as differences (e.g. detachment coded by AV in Chukchi and olfactory AV in Even) between two systems. Syntactically, affixal verbs differ in two systems. In Chukchi all nominal bases of AV constructions cannot be modified externally (1) but can attach incorporated modifiers (2). Thus, in this construction the free nominal stem has more grammatical status as compared to bound AV which is a single predication element (see Keizer 2007; Boye & Harder 2012). In Even, nominal bases of some AV can receive external modification: modification is possible for AV constructions which allow discourse reference to nominal bases, compare (3) and (4) with (5) and (6). Consider also the role of affixal verbs in referential and modificational possibilities of their bases in Kalaallisut (< Eskimo-Aleut) described by Van Geenhoven 1998.

On the basis of previous comparative work (e.g. Fortescue 2005 for Chukchi; Cincius 1975, 1977 for Even) and providing our own reconstructions we argue that the syntactic differences come from the sources of AVs. Chukchi denominal verbalizers function in semantic frames established by noun incorporation and develop either from verbal heads of noun incorporation construction or from reanalysis of deverbal derivations (better understood by constructional approach (Hüning & Booij 2014). Thus, the backgrounded status of a verbalized noun is unsurprising. As for Even, incorporation did not shape AV’s semantic frames and the number of AVs was extended by analogy (including apophony processes).

Appendix

Examples from Chukchi (1)-(2) and from Even (3)-(6)

- (1) **nə-mejəŋ-qin* *ye-kupre-nŋe-ʃin*
 ST-big-ST.3SG PF-net-GET-PF.3SG
 Intended: ‘He bought a big net’.

- (2) *ye-mejŋə-kupre-nŋe-ʃin*
 PF-big-net-GET-PF.3SG
 ‘He bought a big net’.

- (3) *edge-m olla-mi-ri-n*
big-ACC fish-HUNT-PST-3SG
'He caught a big fish'.
- (4) *l'oša olla-mi-ri-n, nan stud'enta-l ere-l-bu žip-ti-tan*
l'osha fish-HUNT-PST-3SG and student-PL DEM.PROX-PL-ACC eat-PST-3PL
'L'osha caught a big fish and students ate it'.
- (5) a. *budele-m-ne-n*
leg-ACHE-NFUT-3SG
'Her/his leg hurts'.
- b. **angida-č budele-m-ne-n*
right-INS leg-ACHE-NFUT-3SG
Intended 'Her/his right leg hurts'.
- (6) **etiken budele-m-ne-n temi tara-w budele-w imu-d-dā-n*
old.man leg-ACHE-NFUT-3SG thus DEM.DIST-ACC leg-ACC smear-PROG-NFUT-3SG
Intended: 'Old man's leg hurts so he smears it with ointment'.

Abbreviations

3 = third person; ACC = accusative; ACHE = ache; DEM.DIST = distant demonstrative; DEM.PROX = proximal demonstrative; GET = get; HUNT = hunt; NFUT = not-future tense; PF = perfect; PL = pluralis; PROG = progressive; PST = past tense; SG = singular; ST = stative

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